

Golden eagle

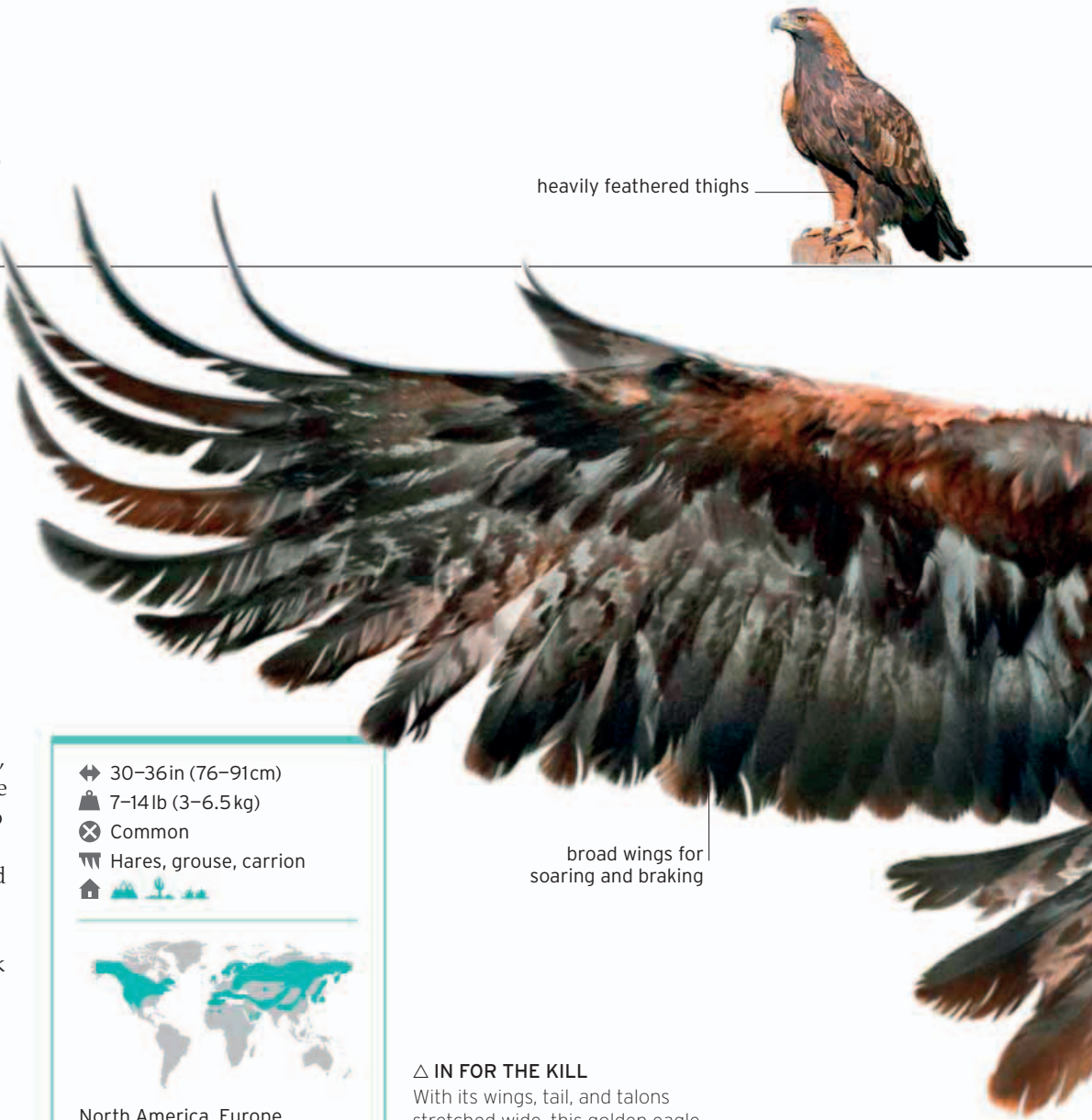
Aquila chrysaetos

Golden eagles fly with incomparable skill and grace over mountain peaks and cliffs, and are often seen merely as dots over a distant high skyline. Their subtly curved wings are held in a shallow "V" as they soar high in the sky. They have excellent sight, several times more acute than a human's, and can see prey such as a mountain hare from 1–2 miles (2–3 km) away. They feed on whatever they can catch up to the size of a goose. In winter, they often eat dead sheep and deer, tearing the carcasses apart with their heavy, hooked bill. Golden eagles fare better on rich moors with plentiful prey than on colder, wetter peaks and forests.

Favorite eyrie

Pairing up for life, golden eagles have several nest sites, but one favored nest, or eyrie, in a tree or on a cliff ledge may become up to 13 ft (4 m) deep as sticks are added to the structure each breeding season. Courtship displays include high soaring, deep switchback undulations, and stunning stoops. In these long plunges with closed wings, the eagles reach extremely high speeds. The female usually lays two eggs, but the first-hatched chick often attacks its younger sibling, and frequently only the stronger, bigger chick survives.

Golden eagles can live for up to 38 years in the wild. However, in some parts of their range they are persecuted by humans and are under threat from activities such as illegal shooting, trapping, and the use of poisoned bait.



heavily feathered thighs

broad wings for soaring and braking

↔ 30–36 in (76–91 cm)

⚖ 7–14 lb (3–6.5 kg)

⊗ Common

🦌 Hares, grouse, carrion

North America, Europe, Asia, N. Africa

△ IN FOR THE KILL
With its wings, tail, and talons stretched wide, this golden eagle swoops down onto its prey, attacking the animal from behind.

Midwife toad

Alytes obstetricans

Looking much like a common European toad at first glance, the midwife toad has a more pointed snout and vertical pupils. The toad's name refers to the way this small amphibian carries around fertilized eggs to keep them out of harm's way while they develop. However, the name is slightly misleading in that it is the male, not the female, that takes care of the next generation. During mating, the male glues the string of eggs to his rump and then delivers them to a pond a few weeks later in time for the tadpoles to hatch.

▷ PATERNAL CARE
The male midwife toad may carry the eggs of more than one mate. It secretes antibiotic mucus to protect the developing young.



↔ 1–2 in (2.5–5 cm)

☁ Spring and summer

⊗ Locally common

🦋 Insects

W. to C. Europe